A healthy diet costs 4.28 PPP dollars a day.

2.7 billion people can’t pay it.

Since 2017 the price of eating well has risen in **166 of 167** countries with data. Yet the share of people priced out of it has fallen to its lowest level in these estimates. This atlas follows that paradox – from global averages to the countries left behind, and to children’s growth.

ONE HEALTHY DIET

1 person, 1 day, world average

Starchy staples	0.54
Vegetables	0.67
Fruits	0.66
Animal-source foods	1.01
Legumes, nuts & seeds	0.37
Oils & fats	0.18
Total, 2021 prices	**3.44**
Healthy diet, 2025	**4.28**
A calorie-only diet, 2021	0.97

Cannot afford it:
2.7 billion people
32.7% of the world

All prices in PPP dollars per person per day.
Source: World Bank, Food Prices for Nutrition 5.0

▼ **How is this measured?**

The cost of a healthy diet is the price of the cheapest locally available foods that meet dietary guidelines across six food groups. It is converted to PPP dollars so that countries can be compared.

A person is counted as unable to afford it when their income cannot cover this diet plus the basic non-food needs typical for their country’s income group.

The paradox

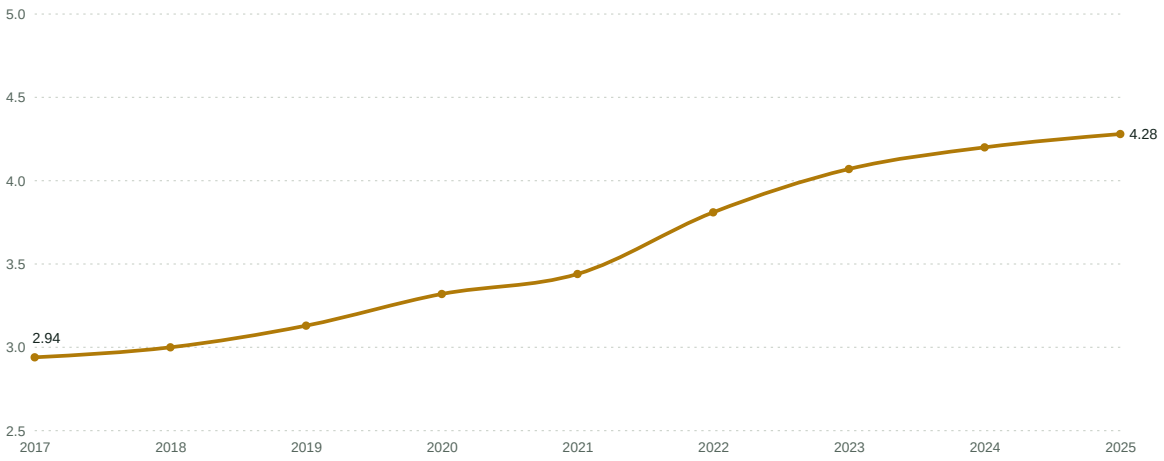
Prices rose. Fewer people were priced out.

Between 2017 and 2025 the daily cost of a healthy diet rose **46%**. Over the same years the share of people who could not afford it fell by **8.3 percentage points**. Read on to see how both can be true.

In 2017 a healthy diet cost **2.94** PPP dollars a day. By 2025 it cost **4.28** – **46% more**.

The cost of a healthy diet keeps climbing

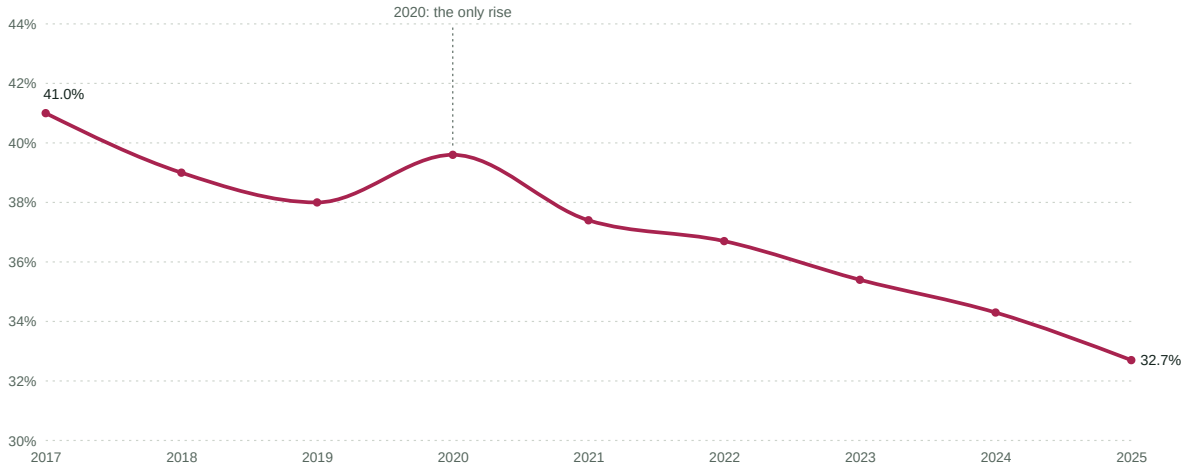
World, 2017–2025. PPP dollars per person per day.



Yet the share of people who cannot afford it fell, from **41.0%** to **32.7%**. Affordability depends on income as well as price. 2020, the first year of the COVID-19 pandemic, was the only year the share rose.

The share priced out is falling

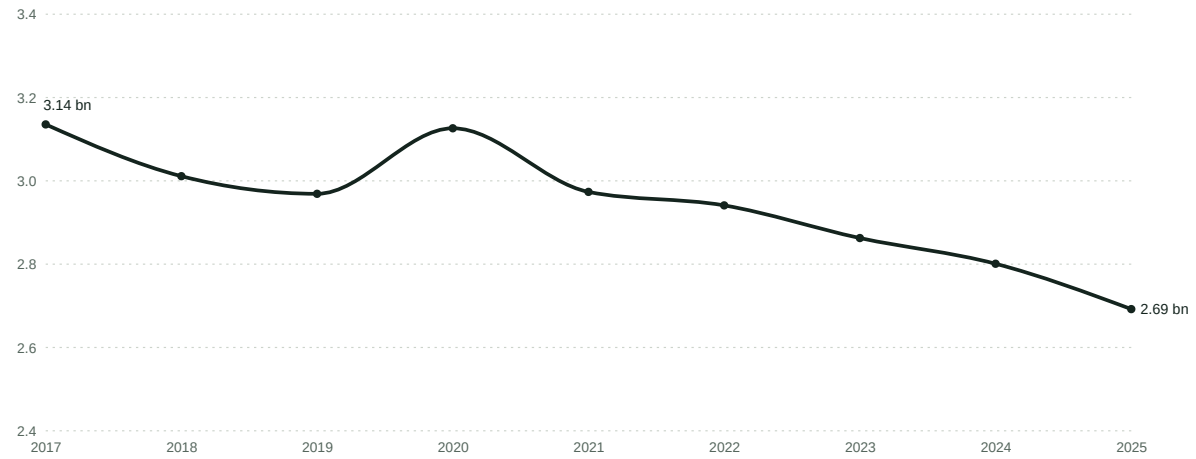
World, 2017–2025. % of people who cannot afford a healthy diet.



Because the world's population grew, the number of people fell more slowly – by 14%, against 20% for the share. **2.69 billion** people still cannot afford a healthy diet.

Still 2.7 billion people cannot afford a healthy diet

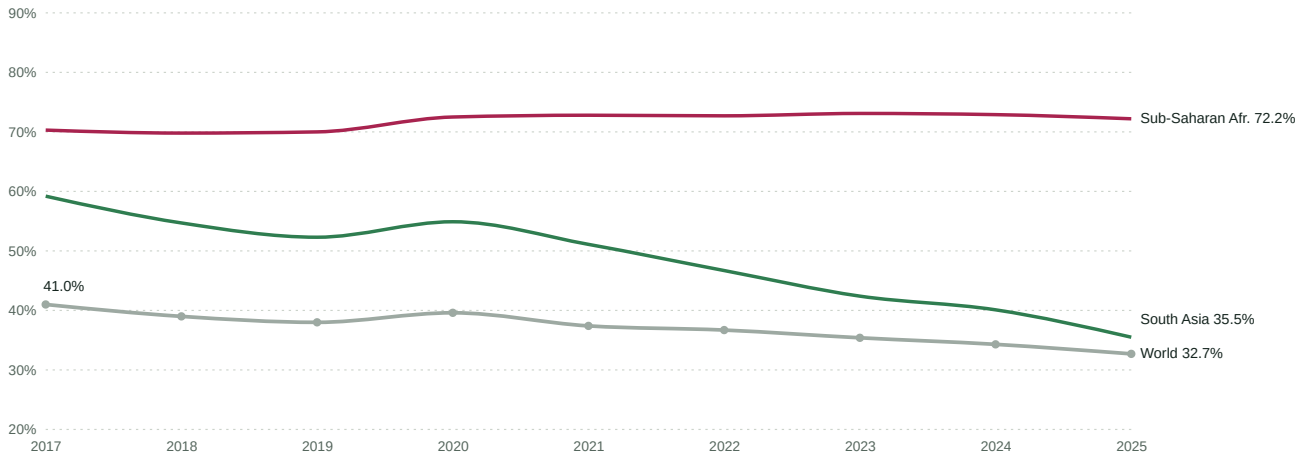
World, 2017–2025. Billions of people who cannot afford a healthy diet.



But the average hides the divide. In South Asia the share fell from **59%** to **36%**. In Sub-Saharan Africa it rose, from **70.3%** to **72.2%**.

The world average hides who was left behind

World and two regions, 2017–2025. % of people who cannot afford a healthy diet.



PPP dollars are international dollars adjusted for what money buys in each country. They are not shop prices or exchange-rate dollars.

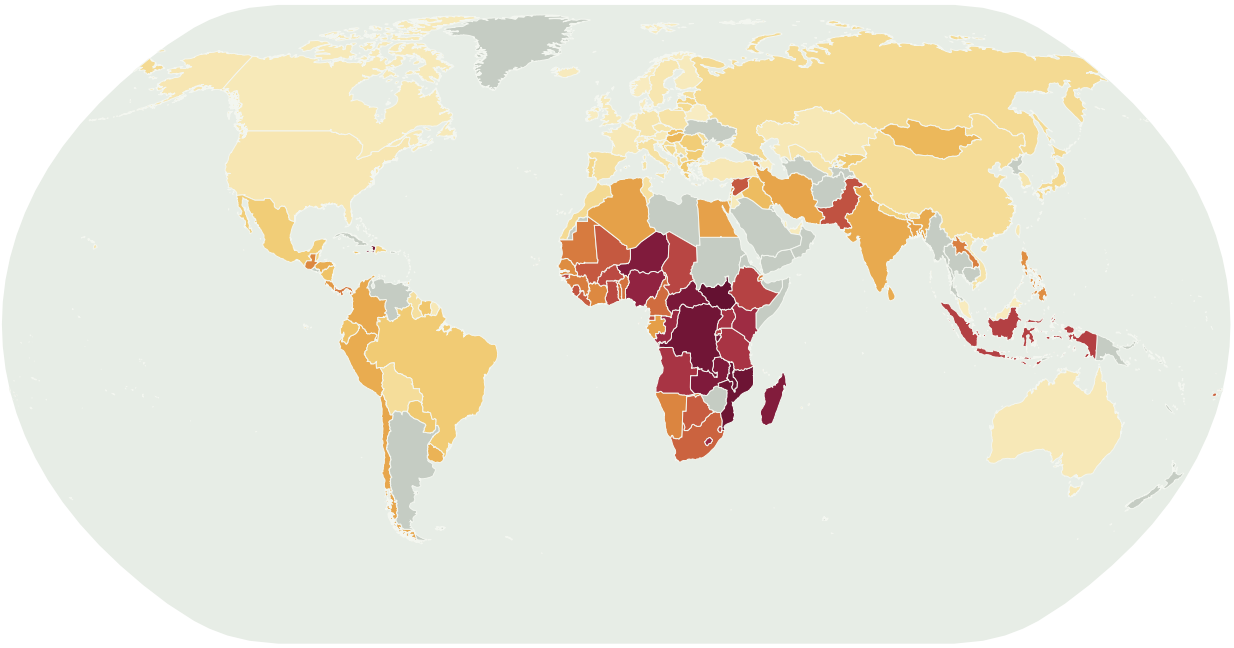
Where

Unaffordability is concentrated in Sub-Saharan Africa

In **41 of 147** countries with an estimate for 2025, more than half the population cannot afford a healthy diet. **35** of them are in Sub-Saharan Africa.

Share of people who cannot afford a healthy diet

Countries, 2025. % of the population.



Share priced out: 0% 100% No estimate

Highest, 2025

South Sudan

93.9%

Lowest, 2025

Belarus

0.6%

Source: World Bank, Food Prices for Nutrition 5.0. Borders: Natural Earth.

▼ How to read this map

Each country is shaded by the indicator you choose. Hover or tap a country for its value. Grey means there is no 2025 estimate – missing data is not the same as no problem: Sudan, Somalia and Zimbabwe are among them. How the share changed since 2017 is shown in the next chapter and in each country's profile below.

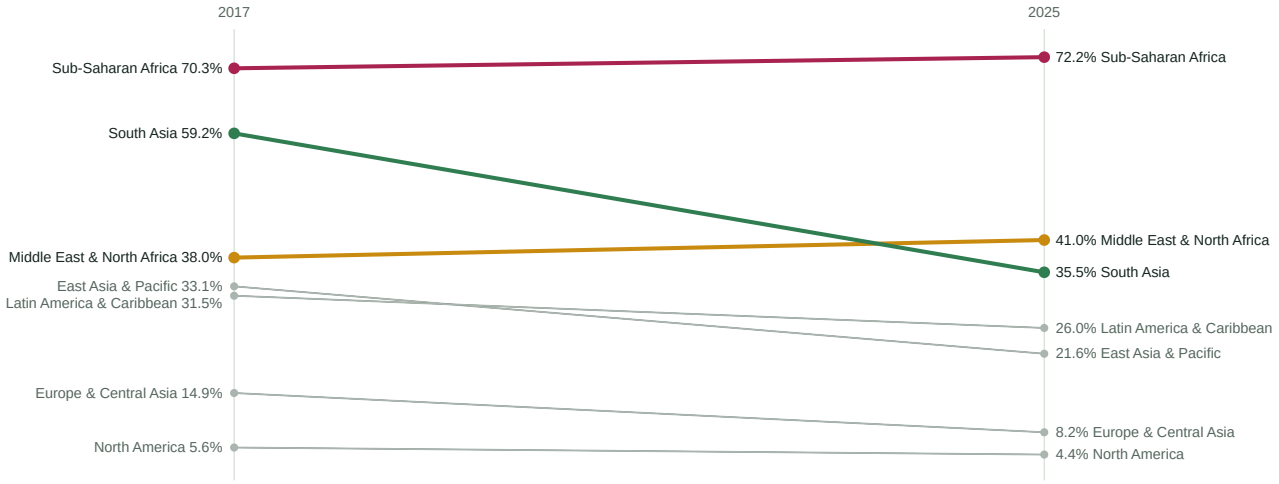
Who’s left behind

Sub-Saharan Africa is moving the other way

South Asia made the biggest gain: the share priced out fell from 59% to 36%. Two regions moved the other way: Middle East & North Africa (38.0% to 41.0%) and Sub-Saharan Africa (70.3% to 72.2%).

Share of people who cannot afford a healthy diet

Regions, 2017 and 2025. % of the population, official World Bank estimates.



Source: World Bank, Food Prices for Nutrition 5.0, official regional aggregates.

> **194 million more people** in Sub-Saharan Africa cannot afford a healthy diet than in 2017. The region now holds **35% of everyone priced out worldwide**, up from 24%.

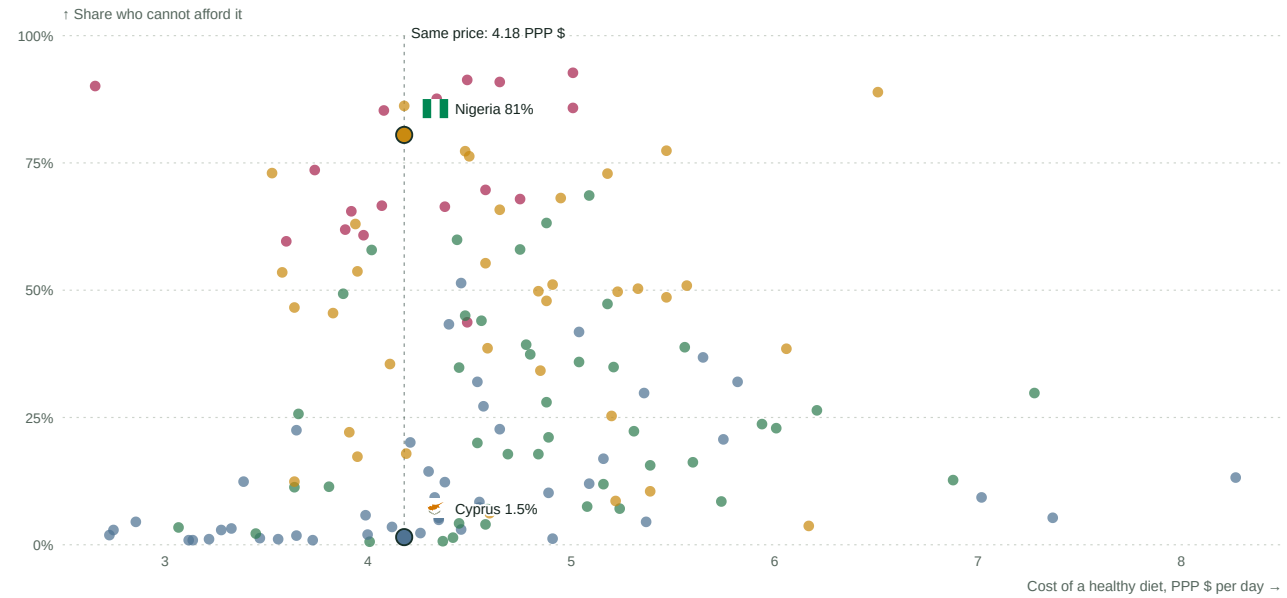
Income, not price

Same price, different worlds

A healthy diet costs about the same in rich and poor countries. In 2025 it cost **4.05** PPP dollars a day in low-income countries and **4.20** in high-income ones – yet **76%** of people in low-income countries could not afford it, against **8.1%**.

Price barely predicts who is priced out (ρ = 0.17, 142 countries)

Countries, 2025. Each dot is a country.



Source: World Bank, Food Prices for Nutrition 5.0; World Development Indicators (GDP per capita, PPP). Income groups: World Bank FY2027.

> In 2025 a healthy diet cost the same in Nigeria and Cyprus: **4.18 PPP dollars a day**. Yet **80.5%** of Nigerians could not afford it, compared with **1.5%** of Cypriots.

▼ How to read this chart

Switch the horizontal axis between the price of a healthy diet and GDP per person (log scale). The vertical axis is the share of people who cannot afford the diet. ρ is the Spearman rank correlation, from −1 to +1. These are associations across countries, not proof of cause; GDP per person is a national average, not household income.

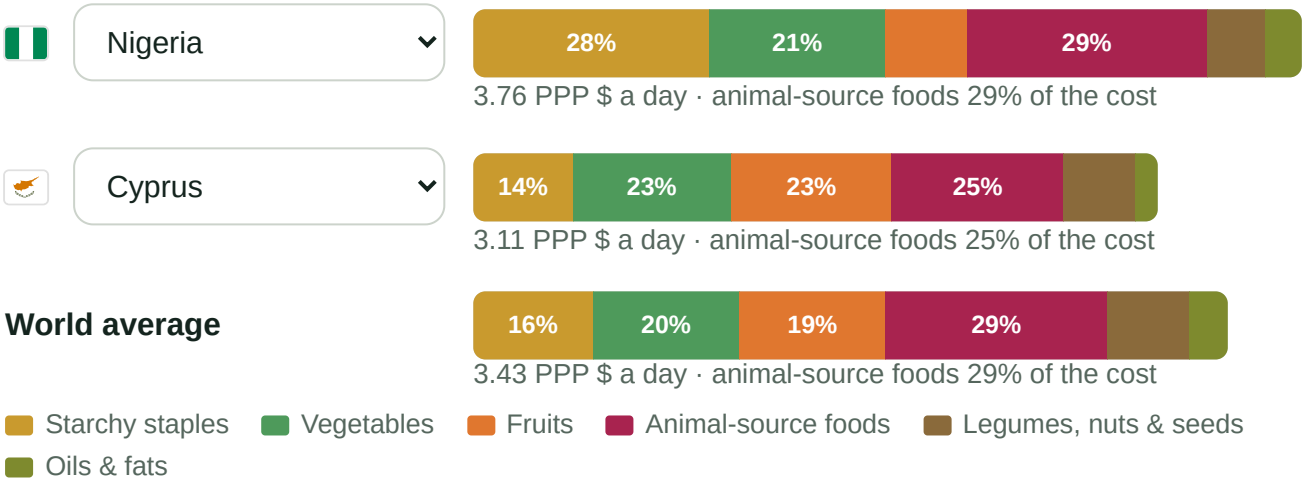
The plate

What makes a healthy plate expensive

A healthy diet costs a median **3.9 times** more than a diet that only fills you up with calories (174 countries, 2021). Animal-source foods, vegetables and fruit make up **68%** of the world-average cost.

Compare two plates

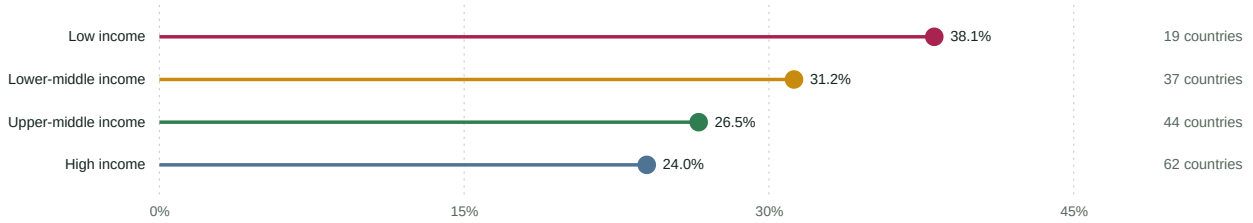
Countries, 2021, the only year with food-group detail. Cost of the cheapest healthy diet, PPP dollars per person per day.



Source: World Bank, Food Prices for Nutrition 5.0 (food-group costs, 2021).

Animal-source foods weigh more on poorer countries' plates

Income groups, 2021, the only year with food-group detail. Median share of the cost of a healthy diet.



In low-income countries, animal-source foods make up a median **38%** of the cost of a healthy diet, against **24%** in high-income countries (2021). This is the cost structure of the cheapest healthy diet, not what families actually buy.

Source: World Bank, Food Prices for Nutrition 5.0. Median across countries with all six food-group costs.

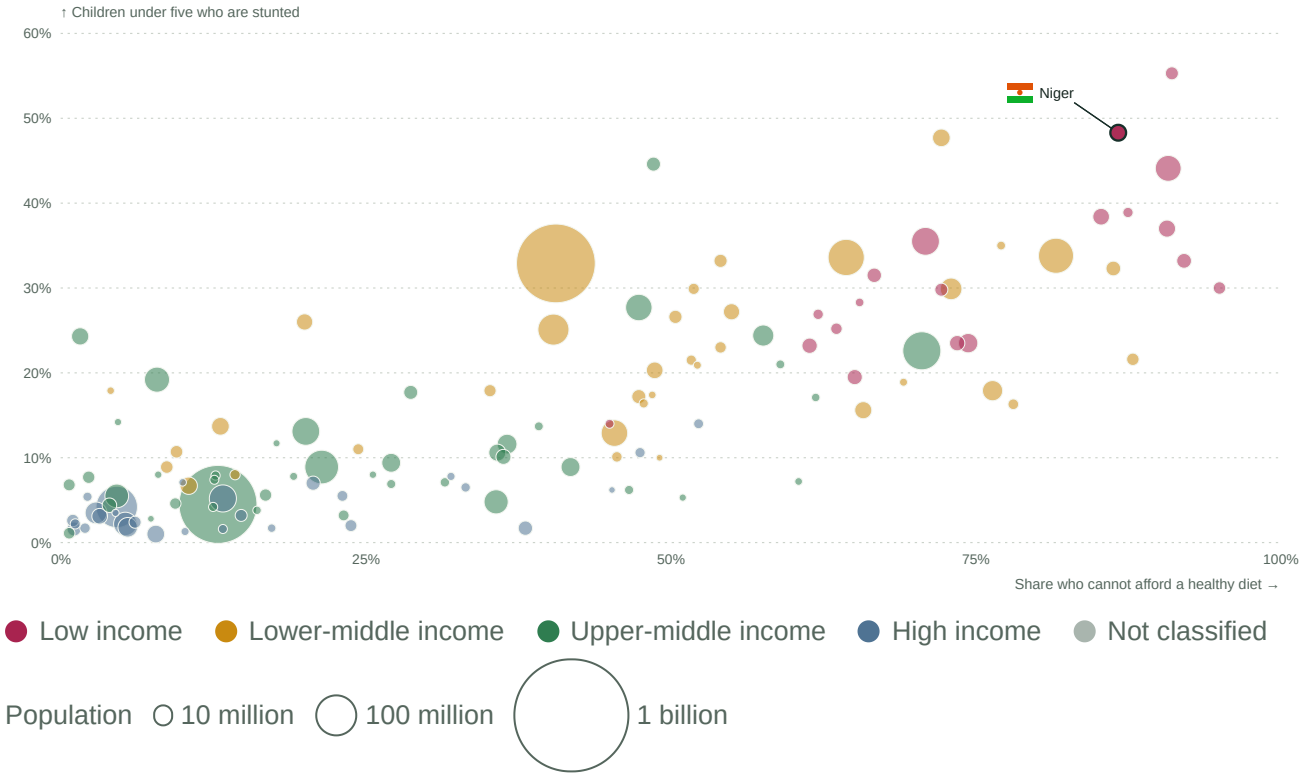
Fed vs. well fed

Being fed is not the same as being well fed

In 2024 at least **570 million** people lacked enough calories in the countries with data – but **2.8 billion** could not afford a healthy diet. Far more people cannot afford a healthy diet than go without enough calories. Stunting – children too short for their age – is one of the clearest signs of long-term poor nutrition.

Where healthy diets are less affordable, more children are stunted (ρ = 0.78, 125 countries)

Countries, 2024, the latest year with nutrition data. Bubble size shows population.



Sources: UNICEF, WHO and World Bank Joint Child Malnutrition Estimates (stunting); FAO FAOSTAT (undernourishment); World Bank Food Prices for Nutrition 5.0.

> In Niger (2024), only **13%** of people lack enough calories – but **87%** cannot afford a healthy diet, and **48%** of children under five are stunted.

▼ How to read this chart

Undernourishment means not getting enough calories (SDG indicator 2.1.1, a three-year average). Stunting means children under five who are too short for their age (SDG 2.2.1). Countries reported as “below 2.5%” undernourishment are left out of the undernourishment comparison. An association across countries is not proof that one causes the other.

Explore

Find your own story

Pick any of 180 countries to see how the cost of a healthy diet and the share of people who cannot afford it have changed since 2017.

Country Nigeria

Nigeria

Sub-Saharan Africa, Lower-middle income

Cannot afford a healthy diet, 2025 **80.5%**	People priced out, 2025 **191 million**
Cost per day, 2025 **4.18 PPP $**	Rank by share, 2025 **11 of 147**
Children stunted, 2024 **33.8%**	Undernourished, 2024 **22.2%**

Since 2017, the cost of a healthy diet rose 50%, while the share of people who cannot afford it rose from 68.6% to 80.5%.

Share who cannot afford it, 2017–2025



Cost, PPP dollars per day, 2017–2025



Highest share priced out

Countries, 2025. Tap a country to open its profile.

1	South Sudan	**93.9%**
2	Malawi	**92.7%**
3	Mozambique	**91.3%**
4	Burundi	**90.9%**
5	DR Congo	**90.1%**

6	Haiti	88.9%
7	Central African Republic	87.6%
8	Zambia	86.2%
9	Niger	85.8%
10	Madagascar	85.3%
11	Nigeria	80.5%
12	Lesotho	77.4%
13	Congo	77.3%
14	Kenya	76.3%
15	Uganda	73.6%

Go deeper

Explore every country and year in the full dashboard

Filter by year, region and income group, compare countries over time and download the data. Built with the same datasets as this story.

Dashboard: food-atlas-3bk2nk.streamlit.app

Opens in a new tab. If the app has been idle it may take up to a minute to wake up.

food-atlas-3bk2nk.streamlit.app

Copy link

Sources and method

Data

- World Bank, *Food Prices for Nutrition*, version 5.0 (July 2026), CC BY 4.0 – cost and affordability of a healthy diet, 2017–2025.
- World Bank, *World Development Indicators* – GDP per capita, PPP

How to read the numbers

- World, regional and income-group figures are the official population-weighted estimates, not averages of countries.
- Food-group costs exist only for 2021, the International Comparison Program price

(current international $), NY.GDP.PCAP.PP.CD (October 2026).

- World Bank, *Country and Lending Groups*, FY2027 classification.
- FAO, *FAOSTAT – Suite of Food Security Indicators*: prevalence of undernourishment (accessed 15 October 2026), CC BY 4.0.
- Method: FAO, *The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World* – cost and affordability of a healthy diet.
- UNICEF, WHO and World Bank, *Joint Child Malnutrition Estimates*, country modelled estimates (March 2026).

benchmark year.

- Undernourishment and stunting end in 2024. Undernourishment is a three-year average shown at its middle year.
- **Why different years?** Each chart uses the latest year its source covers: affordability and cost 2025, nutrition 2024, and food-group costs 2021. Change over time is shown as lines, from 2017 onwards.
- Grey on the map means no estimate. Missing values are never treated as zero.
- All relationships shown are associations across countries, not proof of cause. Correlations (ρ) are unweighted: each country counts once, whatever its population.
- Country-level patterns describe countries, not individual households.
- Coverage: 147 of 180 countries have a 2025 affordability estimate. Missing countries include conflict-affected ones such as Sudan and Somalia, so country counts and rankings cover only countries with data.

SDG 2.1 End hunger

SDG 2.2 End malnutrition

Interactive dashboard (Streamlit) (github.com/Minh-131/Dataviz2026-3BK2NK): every country and year, with filters and data downloads.

Data and code on GitHub (github.com/Minh-131/Dataviz2026-3BK2NK): cleaned datasets, the scripts that build them, and 22 automated checks on every headline number.

The Food Atlas, by Team 3BK2NK for Macquarie University DataViz 2026. An independent student project, not an official UN, FAO or World Bank product. Country flags: flag-icons (MIT). Map: Natural Earth via world-atlas.